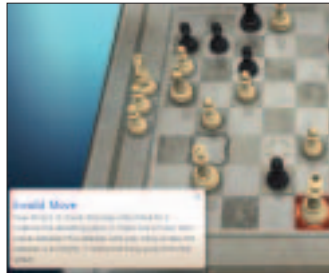


tab. All the games come with handy hints that you can set to display during a game, but you can also download information via the Options tab.

Tip 2

You can play Chess Titans against the computer or another person, and customise the look of your board and pieces. Double-click on the icon, and using the Options tab, choose the level of expertise (1-10), with one being a complete beginner and 10 being the equivalent of a Russian chess master. If your chess is a little rusty, use the Help menu for a refresher course on the rules. The Options menu also offers some useful aid for anyone who's out of practice. You can choose to receive warnings of invalid moves, for example, or show your last move. Tick the Tips option to get hints and advice during a game. If you put yourself into a dangerous situation, the board will highlight the piece in peril and a sound effect warns you. Experts may not like this but you can also undo your last move if you make an error.



Tip 3

Mahjong Titans is a solitaire-style game played with tiles rather than cards. The idea is to remove tiles by matching them, which is easier said than done. While you can match any flower or season tile, all others must be an exact match. You also can't remove matched tiles blocked by other tiles. There are six layouts to choose from and don't despair if you get stuck. In the lower right-hand corner of the screen you will be shown the number of possible matches you can make during a move. The Hint tab in the Games menu will also highlight a match.



Tip 4

Microsoft hasn't forgotten younger players. Purple Place is three games in one; Comfy Cakes, Purple Shop and Purple Pairs. The games are designed to hone skills in memory, pattern recognition

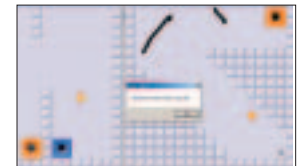


and reasoning. Timers can also be set, so players can work to beat the clock. But the varying degrees of difficulty within the same game mean children can advance at their own pace. Useful hints are given throughout; for example, your goal in Purple Shop is to match your character to

the mystery Purple behind the curtain. Choose features from the shelves. You are then told how many, but not which feature you have right. Click on the big tick to get clues.

Tip 5

More suitable for older children, the idea with Inkball is to use the mouse to draw ink strokes or dots to guide balls into the right holes. Once a ball hits a line this disappears so players need to redraw lines continually. The difficulty level can be set in the menu bar at the top of the game screen. A good tip is to draw a number of lines at various angles. Since the balls bounce back at the angle they hit a wall, it can also be useful to pause the game to attempt a calculation of a ball's trajectory. Click outside the Inkball window to pause. Click inside the window to resume.



Tip 6

Should Vista's new amusements reignite a passion for play, you could consider downloading some new games. A link provided in the Games Explorer bar to Microsoft's games website allows the user to play or buy more games (<http://zone.msn.com/en/root/default.htm>). You'll find something here for just about every taste — puzzles, word games, trivia, card games, board games, arcade games and much more. You can play some online free of charge. Others are free to download but not all levels can be played or they are time-limited. There are also subscription models but this can be expensive. For example, MSN's Gamespring will cost from around Rs. 560 per month, although it does give access to all full versions of the games hosted.

